Lesson 20 material: Interviews: Better Conversations and Good Questions

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

2.1: Watch: Celeste Headlee TED Talk

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Watching a TED Talk

Celeste Headlee "10 Ways to Have a Better Conversation"

Celeste Headlee is an experienced radio host who interviews people for a living. Watch the video and then answer the questions below.

(Online slides or activity: open the original page above.)

- What skill does Celeste Headlee think we need to learn?
- What problems make conversation difficult these days?
- As you hear them in the TED talk, put a check next to the rules for better conversation. Take notes. Be prepared to explain the rules to your classmates.
    - Don't multitask
    - Don't pontificate
    - Ask open-ended questions
    - Go with the flow
    - If you don't know, say you don't know
    - Don't equate your experiences with others
    - Don't repeat yourself
    - Stay out of the weeds
    - Listen
    - Be brief
- According to Celeste Headlee, which rule is the most important?
- In your opinion, which rule is the most important? Do you disagree with any rule? Can you add a rule?
- What does Celeste Headlee mean when she says "Be prepared to be amazed"?
- Remember the video. Which features did the TED talk have? Identify all that apply.
    - Quotes
    - Jokes
    - Visuals
    - Examples
    - A list

- When you have a conversation, what is the best habit you have to make it a good conversation?

Links on the original page

- TED talk: https://www.ted.com/talks/celeste_headlee_10_ways_to_have_a_better_conversation/discussion

2.2: Watch: Brandon Stanton Video Mashup

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Watch Brandon Stanton in Action

Brandon Stanton is a photographer in New York who interviews and writes stories about the strangers he photographs. He has a famous website, Facebook page, and book called Humans of New York (HONY). Watch his video and consider the questions below.

Video: https://youtu.be/8EPUveE04_c

- What kind of questions does Brandon ask when he interviews a stranger?
- What do you notice about his attitude toward the people he interviews?

Links on the original page

- Video (YouTube): https://youtu.be/Bcm6kwWv090

2.3: Question Practice: Profile Diana Nyad

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Diana Nyad

Read the profile of Diana Nyad. Then practice composing questions about the profile.

Pre-reading Questions

Have you ever swum in the ocean? What are some dangers of swimming in the ocean? What is the farthest a human can swim?

Alternative Pre-reading Activity

Diana Nyad's TED talk is available at this link

Diana Nyad Profile

Diana Nyad is the first person to swim from Havana, Cuba to Florida without a shark cage. She swam 110 miles (180 kilometers) and fifty-three hours. She was 64 years old when she accomplished her goal.

How did she do it?

Nyad attempted the swim five times from 2010 to 2013, and did not succeed until her fifth try in 2013. Each time she tried, she had to stop because of storms, jellyfish stings, asthma and shoulder pain. On Sept 2, 2013, she reached her goal despite these setbacks.

She trained by swimming eight to fourteen hours in the ocean every other week. While she was training, she gathered a team of about 35 people. These people helped her while she was swimming. One person paddled beside her in a kayak and used a device to keep sharks away from her. Others helped her put on a suit to keep jellyfish from stinging her. In order to help her swim in a straight line, her team dragged a streamer during the day and LED lights at night behind a boat and she followed them. To keep her mind busy while she was swimming, she thought about books and movies, counted and sang.

When asked about her motivation, she answered, "Because I'd like to prove to the other 60 year-olds that it is never too late to start your dreams."

Question Practice

Use the wh-questions words who, what, when, why, where, how far, how old, how many times to fill in the blanks.

Diana Nyad is the first person to swim from Cuba to Florida without a shark cage.

_____ is the first person to swim from Cuba to Florida without a shark cage?

She swam 110 miles.

_____did she swim?

She was 64 years old.

_____ was she?

Nyad attempted the swim five times.

_____did she attempt the swim?

On September 2, 2013, she reached her goal.

_____ did she reach her goal?

Each time she tried, she had to stop because of storms, jellyfish stings, asthma, and shoulder pain.

_____did she have to stop?

She trained by swimming eight to fourteen hours in the ocean every other week.

_____ did she train?

In order to help her swim in a straight line, her team dragged streamers behind the boat.

_____ did her team drag streamers behind the boat.

To keep her mind busy, she thought about books and movies, counted and sang.

_____did she keep her mind busy?

She gathered a team of 35 people.

_____ people were on her team?

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Links on the original page

- TED talk: https://www.ted.com/talks/diana_nyad_never_ever_give_up

2.4: Question Practice: Profile Stanton

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Watching a Video Profile

Brandon Stanton

Video: https://youtu.be/Bcm6kwWv09o

Video Preview

Watch the video profile about Brandon Stanton. After you watch the video one time, write a few keywords or sentences in your notes. What surprised or interested you about the video? Discuss with your classmates.

Watch Again

Watch the video a second time. This time, imagine that you are the journalist writing a profile of Brandon Stanton. What questions should you ask him to find out more information about his passions? Interviewers should always ask **open-ended** questions. Open-ended questions begin with a "wh" question word and allow for a long answer. Stop the video at the suggested points below and take a few minutes to write down an **open-ended** question for Brandon. The first question has been written for you as an example.

Open-ended question words are ***what, when, where, why, who, how.*** Try to start your question with one of these words.

Example: What do you love about your job?